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Internship Assignment

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Reflecting on My Internship Experience with Amazon

Over the summer, I had the opportunity to work as an area manager intern with Amazon, gaining hands-on experience in managing operations and leading teams within a complex supply chain environment. This internship gave me the chance not only to develop professionally but also to reflect deeply on my own capacity for leadership, motivation, and growth.

I worked approximately 40 hours a week during the internship, although during Amazon's highly demanding Prime Week, I clocked closer to 50 hours. I was placed in a department known as "decant and ship doc," which serves as the initial phase of Amazon's supply chain process. The term "decant" refers to the process of unpacking incoming inventory and preparing it for storage and later fulfillment. As an area manager intern, my job was to oversee the daily workflow of the department, ensure that our unit goals were being met, and most importantly, to manage and support the team of associates under my supervision.

Each day presented its own set of challenges. One of my core responsibilities was to keep the team aligned with the day's production targets. This required continuous communication, proactive planning, and quick decision-making when unexpected issues arose. Additionally, I had to work closely with the ship doc team, particularly in assisting with training decisions and

onboarding new associates. I also maintained a strong focus on safety. Safety is a top priority in Amazon warehouses, and part of my role was to make sure all safety procedures were being followed while also responding promptly to any incidents or hazards. Balancing the urgency of operational goals with the need to maintain a safe and respectful workplace required a level of awareness and adaptability that I had not previously exercised in such a high-pressure environment.

One of the most rewarding parts of the internship was learning how to keep the team motivated. The warehouse setting is not the most dynamic or visually stimulating environment. In fact, it can often feel monotonous and physically draining. I quickly realized that a key part of my job as a leader was to infuse energy and morale into the workspace, even when the surroundings were not particularly exciting. I experimented with different approaches to create a positive atmosphere. For instance, I initiated morning stretch sessions to get everyone physically ready for the day. I also held frequent check-ins to gauge how people were feeling and to provide both encouragement and accountability. Music became a valuable tool as well, helping to set the tone and break the silence that sometimes made the work feel heavier. More than anything, I tried to be approachable and conversational with my team. By simply engaging in dialogue, asking about their day, and listening to their feedback, I found that the workplace became not only more productive but more human.

This internship taught me a variety of new skills, but perhaps the most significant lessons came from the people I worked with. I was genuinely surprised by how willing the associates were to share their knowledge and insights with me. Many of them had been with the company

for years and had accumulated a deep understanding of how things worked, what problems typically arose, and what kind of support they needed from their leaders. I had anticipated that, as an intern, I would be seen as inexperienced or perhaps even as an outsider. Instead, I was welcomed with openness and generosity. The associates understood that I was there to learn, and rather than seeing me as someone who was temporarily passing through, they treated me as someone who could become a real contributor.

Their willingness to help me grow had a profound impact on the way I view leadership. It made me realize that good leadership is not about having all the answers. It is about listening, learning, and lifting others up. I found that when I approached my team with humility and a genuine interest in understanding their experiences, they responded with trust and collaboration. That sense of mutual respect created an environment where we could all succeed.

Looking ahead to future job interviews and career opportunities, I know this internship has significantly strengthened my resume, but more importantly, it has given me real stories and examples to draw upon. I now have firsthand experience managing teams, responding to workplace challenges, and leading in an environment where operations are fast-paced and constantly evolving. I can speak confidently about my ability to communicate under pressure, to motivate a team in difficult conditions, and to implement creative solutions that improve workflow and morale. I have also sharpened my organizational skills, from planning daily production schedules to monitoring safety procedures and balancing the demands of multiple stakeholders. These are all practical, transferable skills that I will carry with me into future roles.

Additionally, my time at Amazon reinforced the importance of soft skills, particularly emotional intelligence. Being able to read the energy of a team, respond with empathy, and create a culture of trust are all essential aspects of successful leadership. During interviews, I plan to highlight how I used these soft skills to not only manage performance but to build strong relationships with my team. Employers are often looking for candidates who can do more than just check off tasks; they want individuals who can lead others, adapt to change, and inspire positive results. This internship gave me a space to grow those abilities, and I am eager to carry them forward into the next phase of my career.

The three pillars of EMPAC, Price, Assortment, and Convenience, were quite visible through the operations we supported. Every process in the warehouse was centered around optimizing speed and accuracy to keep prices low and delivery times fast. By keeping operations efficient, Amazon is able to pass those savings and conveniences on to customers. The scale of product assortment was also staggering. As someone working in the early part of the supply chain, I saw how wide-ranging and diverse the incoming inventory was on a daily basis. The systems in place ensured that this massive assortment of items moved smoothly and predictably through the facility, making it possible for customers to shop with the expectation of variety and availability. The internship helped me understand how each part of the EMPAC model works together to maintain Amazon's competitive advantage, and how my role as an intern contributed to that larger promise.

In conclusion, my internship at Amazon was more than just a summer job. It was a transformative experience that allowed me to grow both personally and professionally. I gained

insight into the complexities of supply chain operations and discovered new strengths within myself. I learned how to lead with empathy, how to stay motivated in challenging environments, and how to turn reflection into meaningful action. Most importantly, I developed a clearer understanding of who I want to be as a leader. As I look forward to graduation and beyond, I know that the lessons from this internship, and the framework provided by the EMPAC model, will continue to guide me. This experience did not just prepare me for a job. It prepared me for a career built on purpose, action, and connection.